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Understanding knowledge's impact on older hospitality workers: The past, present, and future

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ABSTRACT

This study delves into the experiences of older workers involved in the hospitality industry, investigating the significance of previous, current and future knowledge in equipping their hospitality careers. The conceptual notions of the knowledge-based view of the firm were appraised. Semi-structured open-ended interviews conducted among 56 older workers involved in both managerial and non-managerial positions highlighted the magnitude of 11 conceptual dimensions. Among these, the organisational, human resource, and self-development uplift dimensions help explain how previous knowledge has equipped participants and their firms. Similarly, the organisational momentum or career-enlightening dimensions elucidate current knowledge in fortifying earlier accumulated knowledge, while future required knowledge can be understood by the individual-organisational and generational-team bridging dimensions. The analysis also reveals alignments between the crafted dimensions and the knowledge-based model. A developed framework resulting from the compendium of dimensions, together with the identified alignments, underscores implications for hospitality employees, their firms, industry and policymakers.

1. Introduction

The world's aging population is increasing significantly (Hu et al., 2023), and projections suggest that such a trend will continue (e.g., United Nations, 2023). This phenomenon has clear repercussions in the work environment, illustrated by an ageing workforce (Lu and Zhou, 2024; North, 2019) and a postponement of the retirement age (Calzavara et al., 2020). While definitions of older workers vary (Stoesz et al., 2020), and their terminology and age criteria fall short of an appropriate conceptualisation (Ryan et al., 2017), they can be understood as those individuals aged above 50 or 55 years (Peng and Chan, 2019). Although through the years older workers may experience cognitive or physical decline, given their experience, they represent a valuable organisational asset (Calzavara et al., 2020). Experience is, in turn, innately attached to time, which enables building job-related knowledge (Sturman, 2003).

Knowledge thus represents a key attribute and contribution of older employees and can be impactful on the hospitality industry, which

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provides services dependent upon knowledge-based processes (Mota Veiga et al., 2023). This point is partly aligned with one of the pillars of the resource-based view of the firm, which predicates that knowledge has the highest strategic significance among a firm's resources (Grant, 1996). Within organisations, knowledge can be perceived differently among older workers, in that they place a higher value on practical rather than new or specialised knowledge (Taylor et al., 2010). Moreover, older employees' knowledge of various professional settings and cultures, alongside specific competencies and life experience, equips them with differentiated skills to integrate or interpret information (Ebrahimi et al., 2008), with implications for their productivity and firms' competitiveness.

As demographic changes result in higher numbers of older workers (Profili et al., 2017), integrating their knowledge more swiftly (Calzavara, 2020) while finding adequate engagement to fulfil their roles becomes crucial (Ebrahimi et al., 2008). These notions also underscore the significance of previous or prior knowledge through older employees' accumulation of earlier experiences. Dochy and Alexander (1995) conceptualise previous knowledge "as the whole of a person's knowledge" (p. 227), and prior knowledge as structured and dynamic knowledge that can be tacit or explicit. Prior knowledge can, therefore, be associated with prior tacit knowledge (Marvel and Droege, 2010), and with learning and alertness (Hajizadeh and Zali, 2016).

Tacit knowledge is reflected among older employees through their understanding of a company's norms, culture or politics (Joe et al., 2013). Tacit knowledge falls under the umbrella of the resource-based view and constitutes a valuable asset that can improve an organisation's competitiveness (Pereira and Bamel, 2021). In this context, organisations should devise a strategy for a successful knowledge transfer between older and other employees within their workforce (Calo, 2008). Ranasinghe et al. (2024) also suggest other supporting initiatives, including continuous improvement, monitoring and evaluation and identification of training needs. Arguably, these remedial steps can enhance knowledge management, which entails a systematic and deliberate approach to guarantee the comprehensive operationalisation of a knowledge foundation (Dalkir, 2005). Knowledge management is linked to individual ideas, competencies, skills, or thoughts that contribute to greater effectiveness and efficiency (Dalkir, 2005) and, by extension, to the professional contribution of older employees.

While studies focusing on the aging population in the hospitality industry (e.g., Ann and Blum, 2020; Canning, 2011; Poulston and Jenkins, 2016) have increased (Fan et al., 2024), research investigating the connection between older employees and facets of knowledge management in the hospitality industry is scant. More specifically, a noticeable gap exists regarding the examination of previous, current, and future knowledge among older hospitality employees. These knowledge-based transitions through knowledge acquisition, accumulation and absorption of new knowledge among this hospitality cohort could be insightful from an empirical and conceptual viewpoint. Indeed, hospitality employees' innovative behaviour can be enabled by knowledge application and knowledge-sharing behaviour (Lee and Kim, 2017). Additionally, accumulating and sharing knowledge can result in attracting and retaining patrons and enhancing their satisfaction (Chen and Cheng, 2012). Furthermore, learning how knowledge equips older workers through their career paths could help guide future generations of hospitality workers to understand and become more adaptable at a time when the aging workforce is rising (e.g., Blomé et al., 2020). This point aligns with contemporary research (Tang and Martins, 2021) that ascertains the importance of intergenerational knowledge-sharing at a company level, and calls for its incorporation into human resource strategies, emphasising the value of older employees in this process.

Against this backdrop, the study will illuminate and improve the extant knowledge of older employees' perceptions regarding the role of knowledge in their profession. By gathering the observations of 56 hospitality employees in managerial and non-managerial roles, the study will first expand on an unresearched area concerning older workers. Moreover, the research's main foci are associated with: a) how previous knowledge has influenced older workers, b) how knowledge currently influences them, and c) how older workers expect future knowledge, including new and adaptive knowledge, to influence their profession. In doing so, the study also fills an additional knowledge gap, namely, concerning the experiences and potential challenges that older workers face in hospitality/tourism work environments; to date, this theme has received scant attention (Madera et al., 2023).

The study will, therefore, make empirical contributions, for instance, informing hospitality workers, the hospitality industry and researchers of the impacts that can be accrued through knowledge acquisition, absorption, exchange and application over time. This impact is significant as the aging phenomenon will permeate and be increasingly present in different industries, including the hospitality industry. Second, the study incorporates a qualitative method, thereby extending the limited body of qualitative research in the domain of older employees while also addressing the aforementioned research gaps. Indeed, there is an argument regarding the limitations of quantitative approaches in the context of research on older hospitality employees, specifically from the perspective of hotel managers (e.g., Cheung and Woo, 2021). Third, the study will make a conceptual contribution through the crafting of various dimensions and a proposed model. The study's central theme, knowledge management across various stages of older employees' professional path, encourages reflecting and drawing on the tenets of the knowledge-based view (KBV) of the firm (e.g., Grant, 1996), discussed next. Importantly, the KBV is identified as an outgrowth of the afore-mentioned resource-based view framework (e.g., Grant, 1996). This link is based on the commonalities between the two philosophies, sharing similar conceptual foundations, with the KBV emphasising the significance of knowledge as a vital strategic resource more strongly (Durst and Khadir, 2025).

2. Literature review

2.1. Theoretical background: knowledge, Knowledge management and the KBV

Often referred to as a firm's intellectual capital, knowledge is the most significant and critical resource a firm possesses (Civi, 2000). Knowledge is also a fluctuating combination of expert insights, values, experience and contextual information and is generated and applied in the minds of those creating it (Davenport and Prusak, 1998). Within a firm setting, knowledge can become embedded in documents, organisational processes, norms, routines and practices (Davenport and Prusak, 1998). Two types of knowledge are often presented in the literature: explicit and tacit (Civi, 2000), with the two interacting with one another to build knowledge (Nonaka et al., 2000). Demonstrations of explicit knowledge include manuals, formulae or data, which can be a) expressed in an organised and formal language and b) more easily communicated, processed or stored (Nonaka et al., 2000). Contrarily, tacit knowledge is difficult to convey formally or conceptualise as it is highly personal, subjective and demands simultaneous processing (Nonaka et al., 2000; Schoenherr, 2022). Tacit knowledge also encompasses intuition, hunches and subjective insights (Nonaka et al., 2000); it reflects an individual's experience, perspectives, mental models or beliefs as opposed to knowledge that can be captured in writing (Schoenherr, 2022).

Aligned with the conceptualisation of knowledge, and extending Dalkir's (2005) ideas, knowledge management can be considered 'an evolving practice' (Davenport and Prusak, 1998) and a process in which firms develop and utilise their knowledge (Civi, 2000). One of the foci of knowledge management is to organise and facilitate the use of knowledge as needed in a timely and accessible manner; increasingly, knowledge management entails the handling of important tacit knowledge (Sabherwal and Sabherwal, 2005).

Following these premises, the KBV embodies an amalgamation of

ideas and juxtaposition of research streams that highlight the function of knowledge in the very existence of a firm, including its management and development (Grant and Phene, 2022). However, while the firm is the ultimate recipient of knowledge-based resources, knowledge is held by both organisations and their people (Ferreira et al., 2022). Moreover, the KBV underscores coordination mechanisms that contribute to firms' integration of specialist knowledge residing in their members (Grant, 1996), thus emphasising the value of individual knowledge. Therefore, considering the KBV to illuminate research concerning individuals' knowledge, including the stages of previous knowledge development and accumulation, current and future knowledge, could be insightful.

Apart from illuminating the present research through its conceptual facets, a key rationale for embracing the KBV's underpinnings is represented by Grant's (1996) contribution, where a suite of characteristics of knowledge was developed and proposed. These premises also help understand some of the phases of elderly employees' knowledge experiences (previous, present, and future) the present study focuses on:

Knowledge *appropriability* stresses how easily a firm's knowledge can be replicated or protected from such imitation (Saarenketo et al., 2009; Schoenherr, 2022), and the returns the owners of knowledge can receive through the value created by its application and use (Schlegel and Kraus, 2023). Appropriability emphasises the firm as the subject seeking to protect its ideas from competitors, for instance, through patent protection and tacit knowledge (Saarenketo et al., 2009). However, Saarenketo et al. (2009) concluded that the two are separate and cannot be assessed as one-dimensional; for instance, tacit knowledge is ingrained in and accumulated among individuals (Nonaka et al., 2000).

Concerning the present research, older employees can be 'translators of history' and previous situations pertaining to a firm's registered information (Ebrahimi et al., 2008). Moreover, their professional mindset and pivotal role in engaging in internal activities such as training (Cheung and Woo, 2021) and their year-long industry experience can result in substantial knowledge aggregation and appropriability at an individual level. Thus, while the firm is at the centre of appropriability, there is clearly a knowledge-based individual element where, through their previously accumulated knowledge and resulting skills and expertise, individual employees are major producers of knowledge appropriability. These notions, coupled with the emerging demographic phenomenon represented by an increasingly aging population, suggest the need for organisations to operationalise effective strategies designed to recruit and retain older workers (Cheung and Woo, 2021). The exhibited characteristics of knowledge appropriability in helping explain previous knowledge support the proposal of the following research question (RQ):

RQ1: How does previous knowledge equip older employees for their careers' current demands, in particular, for those in the hospitality industry?

Knowledge *transferability* is crucial, in particular within a firm (Grant, 1996). Here, again, explicit and tacit knowledge are central to understanding transferability. Indeed, while explicit knowledge emerges through the ease of communication as its central property, tacit knowledge is application-based and its properties prevent codification (Grant, 1996). From an organisational and hospitality industry point of view, while there is an expectation of tacit knowledge-sharing (Lu and Zhou, 2024), older workers' experience and knowledge are difficult to transfer among other co-workers in tacit ways.

For instance, Lu and Zhou (2024) found that older workers' perceptions of deep-level knowledge differences with their younger counterparts inhibited their knowledge-sharing. Ebrahimi et al.'s (2008) study revealed the importance of socialisation as a medium to pass on tacit knowledge; however, rendering tacit knowledge explicit requires the involvement of the managerial system as an initiator and enabler of knowledge circulation. Hence, there is a link between the operationalisation of previous (tacit/explicit) knowledge and that of current knowledge. Furthermore, Wikström et al. (2018) bemoan the lack of procedures preventing the retention of older/senior employees' tacit knowledge, which contributes to their negative perceptions of handing over specific knowledge. Calo (2008) cautions that tacit knowledge's embeddedness in context and individuals results in an uncertain and slow transfer; as a result, it is a challenging aspect of knowledge management processes.

Overall, while opportunities and challenges exist for older employees to engage in knowledge-sharing with their peers (Lu and Zhou, 2024), there is a need for an organisation's involvement (Ebrahimi et al., 2008; Wikström et al., 2018) for current knowledge to be operationalised, in this case, through its transfer within the organisation.

The knowledge requirements of production: Production implies that inputs are transformed into outputs where the key source of value is knowledge; moreover, human productivity depends upon knowledge, whereas machines are merely personifications of knowledge (Grant, 1996). This characteristic, therefore, underscores the significance of the individual in maximising knowledge in production, including through their daily knowledge usage and highlights the relevance of current knowledge, including acquisition and sharing. These elements are also related to knowledge retention, which, in the case of older (and retiring) employees is influenced by knowledge as well as individual, contextual, and relation factors (Burmeister and Deller, 2016).

In addition, Grant (1996) underlines that operationalising knowledge in production could also be supplemented by the combination of existing and new knowledge acquisition (Grant, 1996), which relates to this study's focus on current and future knowledge. The organisation's role is once again crucial in allocating structures across departments, together with training and rewards systems (Costa and Monteiro, 2018). Through these steps, the organisation can reinforce and encourage individuals' learning with implications for absorptive capacity (Costa and Monteiro, 2018), which, in turn, can reinforce knowledge retention.

The nuances between knowledge transferability and the knowledge requirements of production thus suggest the value of the following RQ:

RQ2: How does current knowledge equip older employees for their career demands, in this case, in their hospitality industry career?

Capacity for knowledge aggregation is contingent upon an individual's capacity to complement existing knowledge with newly acquired knowledge (Grant, 1996) or add individual portions of knowledge while engaged in knowledge absorption (Schlegel and Kraus, 2023). Thus, this characteristic juxtaposes two of the study's central themes: current and future knowledge. Nevertheless, examining the work of Cohen and Levinthal (1990), Schoenherr (2022) associates this characteristic with absorptive capacity, where prior knowledge provides a foundation upon which new knowledge can be developed, resulting in enhanced innovative capabilities; thus, once acquired and absorbed, knowledge can be operationalised and shared.

Similarly, problem-solving techniques and methods represent the prior knowledge needed to gain associated problem-solving capabilities (Cohen and Levinthal, 1990). This notion suggests the progressive path between previous and current knowledge, where the former helps support or strengthen the latter, and further underscores the value of the KBV in exploring older employees' knowledge-related progression through their hospitality careers.

While older employees are portrayed as more resistant to change and less agile in learning (Williams van Rooij, 2012), those who receive appropriate training are likely to exhibit greater loyalty to their employer than other groups (Taylor and Bisson, 2020), with implications for maximising their knowledge-based potential. Regarding their learning, Findsen (2015) recommends a 'negotiated' process where older employees assume more autonomy, for instance, through training.

Specialisation in knowledge acquisition: Citing the work of Simon (1957), Grant (1996) explains that, to efficiently create new knowledge and acquire and store knowledge, specialising in specific areas is required. In the same vein, this characteristic is concerned with how individuals' specialisation in distinctive professional domains is linked to efficient knowledge creation (Schlegel and Kraus, 2023). The element of new knowledge creation underscores the importance of future

activities and undertakings where existing knowledge is enhanced, extended, complemented, or strengthened. With the dynamic state of automation and technological developments, workers must acquire new skills and be able to work with machines (Yang et al., 2023). These demands will also be placed upon older workers. Willems and Poon (2024) recommend integrating older workers' expertise and younger generations' technological fluency, fostering the development of an innovative and resilient talent pool. This point is also validated by hospitality inquiry emphasising generational interaction (Chi et al., 2013). The linkages between the above two characteristics of knowledge and future knowledge suggest the merit of examining the following RQ:

RQ3: What future knowledge will equip older employees to adapt to the demands of an ever-changing work environment, in this case, the hospitality industry?

While older workers have accumulated extensive knowledge-based skills, various studies suggest the need for organisational strategies to help mitigate negative stereotypes that can also have a profound impact on this group. Indeed, although older workers are perceived to possess strong levels of soft qualities, these are seldom advantageous in productivity-based evaluations (Cheung and Woo, 2021), clearly underlining the necessity to identify a fairer process. Furthermore, a frequently unsubstantiated bias exists through such negative perceptions as older workers' reluctance to embrace new technologies, unwillingness to change, or being less productive or energetic at work (Ranasinghe et al., 2024). Exploring perceived employment challenges among older workers requires understanding the complex nature of factors such as age and its influence on these workers' experiences in the workplace (Seo et al., 2024).

Several initiatives, some associated with knowledge-based initiatives, have been proposed, ranging from training and retraining, upskilling to meet the evolution of job markets (Seo et al., 2024) or nurturing constructive work environments (Ranasinghe et al., 2024). In addition, when properly managed, intergenerational learning, together with peer learning, or mentorship programs, can provide opportunities for knowledge transfer between age groups (Ranasinghe et al., 2024), potentially minimising age-related stereotypes.

Furthermore, although the KBV has been embraced in hospitality and tourism research (e.g., Chen and Lee, 2017; Nieves et al., 2014; Vu et al., 2023), its usefulness in illuminating knowledge-related aspects of older employees' professional journey has not been established; as a result, conceptual understanding is lacking. With the prospects of a stronger representation of the older employee cohort in the hospitality industry being estimated for years or decades (Ann and Blum, 2020; Iun and Huang, 2007; Poulston and Jenkins, 2016), generating a deeper understanding of the knowledge journey could be insightful and valuable for practitioners and researchers. Against this backdrop, the following RQ will also be investigated:

RQ4: How appropriate is the RBV in gaining an understanding of older hospitality employees' knowledge-based journey?

2.2. The study's context

This study chooses the case of Vietnam, one of the world's 16 most populous nations and population density (Statista, 2024a). Importantly, in 2023, Vietnam's population rose above 100 million, and whereas its population is relatively young, it began a rapid ageing process in recent years (Statista, 2024a). In Vietnam, 82.7 per cent of the 50–54-year-old citizens participate in the labour force (Statista, 2024b). In comparison, 68.7 per cent of those aged 55–59 years, 48.3 per cent of the 60–67-year-old group and 21.1 per cent of citizens over 65 years of age are still engaged in the labour force (Statista, 2024b).

As in previous years, Vietnam's hospitality and tourism have continued to be recognised with international accolades. Recent awards include the 2024 World's Best Culinary City Destination (Hanoi), Asia's Best Hotel Restaurant 2024, and the 2024 World's Best Brunch Venue (Hanoi) (World Culinary Awards, 2024). Studying hospitality employees operating in Vietnam's hospitality industry concerning knowledge management, for instance, the importance of previous, current, and perceptions of future knowledge, could yield valuable insights that could strengthen efforts to enhance knowledge and, therefore, employees' adaptability and competitiveness.

3. Methodology

3.1. Approaches and methods

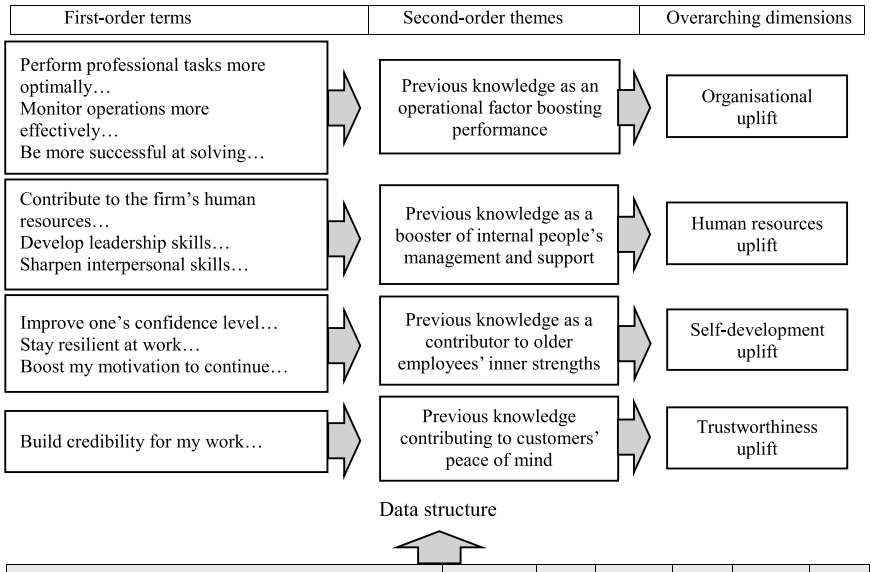
This study takes an exploratory and qualitative approach, a decision aligned with Creswell (2009), who emphasises the value of qualitative research to explore and understand the meaning ascribed by an individual or groups to problems of social or human nature. Indeed, qualitative research is useful and exploratory in cases when researchers lack knowledge regarding the key variables to study or when a phenomenon or concept lacks understanding due to limited research (Creswell, 2009). Moreover, in qualitative studies, understanding a phenomenon as opposed to making generalisations is the fundamental goal (Forman and Damschroder, 2008). The strong links between a qualitative approach and inductive data analysis also justify embracing this paradigm, which consists of building categories, themes, or patterns using a bottom-up analytical process, where, increasingly, the data organisation becomes increasingly abstract (Creswell, 2009). Ultimately, this process evolves into the development of "a framework of the underlying structure of experiences or processes that are evident in the raw data" (Thomas, 2006, p. 237).

Purposive sampling is also embraced in this research. This method entails making decisions regarding the inclusion of particular individuals in their investigation, for instance, based on their specialist knowledge or capacity to be involved in the investigation (Jupp, 2006). The study considered the involvement of individuals working in hotels. In late 2023, coinciding with the preparations for the festive season (Christmas and Vietnam's Tet holidays), members of the research team used websites to identify potential hotel managers and employees in non-managerial positions when applicable and conducted on-site observations in Hanoi, Vietnam's capital. Aligned with research in workplace learning (e.g., Yamazaki et al., 2018) and the hospitality industry (Doyle et al., 2012), one key reason to elicit information from these two groups included the potential for comparisons in their experiences and viewpoints. As illustrated in Figs. 1–3, this approach helped reveal various differences in perceptions regarding previous, current and future knowledge.

The proximity of some research team members to this city and its recent hospitality industry accolades (World Culinary Awards, 2024) were determinant factors in choosing this city. A similar approach was undertaken in two other major Vietnamese cities (Ho Chi Minh, Danang), which led to reaching out to 77 potential candidates for the research; 35 and 42 of these individuals worked in managerial and non-managerial positions, respectively (Table 1). These individuals were contacted both by email correspondence and in person; a brief outline of the research was presented. Simultaneously, an invitation was extended for them to share their experiences through a face-to-face or online interview. In the following weeks, contact was re-established with these individuals; in total 56 (27 managerial, 29 non-managerial employees) were willing to partake in the study. This number is within the norm for qualitative interviews presented by Saunders and Townsend (2016).

3.2. Data collection

Between March and September 2024, semi-structured open-ended interviews were carried out; 21 of these were face-to-face and 35 were online. The interviews lasted 40 min on average and were conducted in Vietnamese by several team researchers. In at least 21 cases, the interviews allowed for on-site observations to have a deeper



Previous knowledge has equipped me to…	Manager (n=27)	%*	Staff (n=29)	%*	Total (n=56)	%*
Perform professional tasks more optimally (e.g., in less time, with less effort and more flexibly).	16	59.3	21	72.4	37	66.1
Contribute to the firm's human resources (e.g., through training and sharing experiences with young employees).	13	48.1	4	13.8	17	30.4
Monitor operations more effectively (e.g., minimising risks by anticipating costs and managing inventory).	12	44.4	2	6.9	14	25.0
Improve one's confidence level (e.g., in making decisions and demonstrating work-related capabilities).	11	40.7	6	20.7	17	30.4
Stay resilient at work (e.g., in persevering with my work).	9	33.3	3	10.3	12	21.4
Build credibility for my work in the customers' eyes.	9	33.3	5	17.2	14	25.0
Be more successful at solving work-related problems.	7	25.9	3	10.3	10	17.9
Develop leadership skills based on accumulated experiences (e.g., adapting to transitional stages/events).	6	22.2	1	3.4	7	12.5
Sharpen interpersonal skills (e.g., communication, building relationships, connecting departments).	4	14.8	4	13.8	8	14.3
Boost my motivation to continue self-learning (e.g., to become more multitasking).	1	3.7	8	27.6	9	16.1

* Percentages were rounded off as appropriate.

Fig. 1. How previous knowledge has equipped older hospitality workers.

understanding of participants' activities and demonstrations of knowledge acquisition, application and maximisation. Data saturation began to manifest itself after the 25th interview with each group; however, the study adheres to notions of data appropriateness (O'Reilly and Parker, 2013) as a decisive criterion. The interview protocol encompassed two steps. First, questions were asked to collect participants' demographic information (e.g., gender, age group, role, and years of experience). Second, the following open-ended questions (Q) were posed:

Q1: How has previous knowledge equipped you for the demands of the hospitality industry?

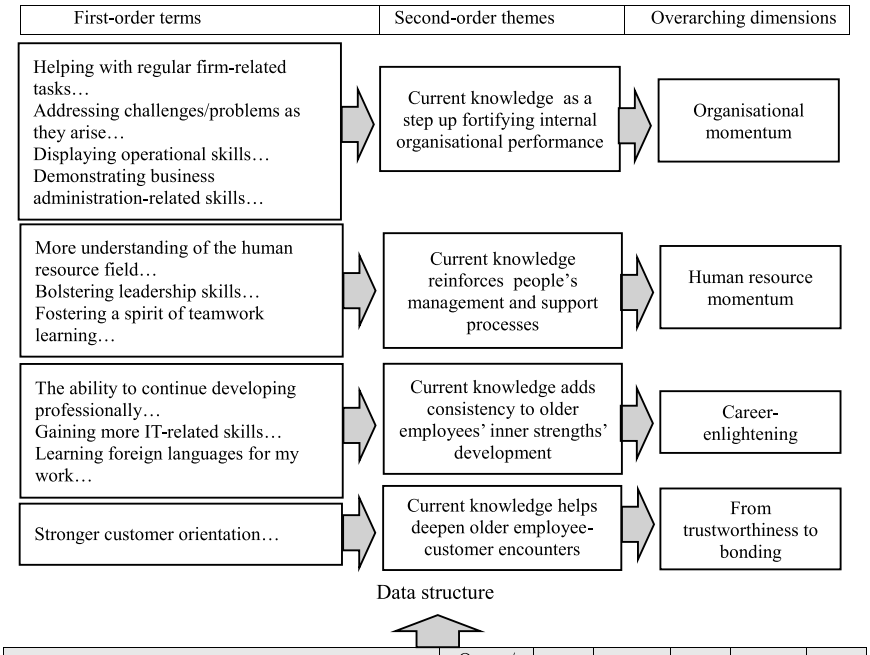
Q2: How does current knowledge continue to equip you for the demands of the hospitality industry?

Q3: What future knowledge will equip older employees to adapt to the demands of an ever-changing hospitality industry?

These questions were developed considering various academic sources that focused on knowledge management, knowledge development and the hospitality industry (e.g., Chen and Cheng, 2012; Cheung and Woo, 2021; Chi et al., 2013; Civi, 2000; Lee and Kim, 2017; Sabherwal and Sabherwal, 2005). The questions also emerged through the literature review, which depicts linkages between these questions, the KBV's characteristics of knowledge and the study's objectives (Grant, 1996; Grant and Phene, 2022; Schlegel and Kraus, 2023; Schoenherr, 2022). As previously ascertained, Q1 is associated with the knowledge appropriability characteristic (Grant, 1996), while Q2 aligns with knowledge transferability and the knowledge requirements of production. Finally, the capacity for knowledge aggregation and the specialisation in knowledge acquisition characteristics suggest the future need for knowledge enrichment, aligning most closely with Q3.

3.3. Data analysis and aspects related to trustworthiness

The interviews were first transcribed and translated by the research team members in collaboration with four external researchers and a professional translator. The raw data were then scrutinised through qualitative content analysis (QCA) and data structure. QCA comprises the use of code categories that are revealed in the data and the application of these through meticulous analysis; furthermore, QCA "treats counting as the detection of patterns to guide the further interpretation of the data" (Morgan, 1993, p. 116). Thus, QCA's objective is to condense and attain a broad narrative of a phenomenon under inquiry through categories of concepts that usually result in building a conceptual map, system or model (Elo and Kyngäs, 2008).



Current knowledge equips me by/through…	Owner/ manager (n=27)	%*	Staff (n=29)	%*	Total (n=56)	%*
Helping with regular firm-related tasks (e.g., standard operating procedures).	9	33.3	24	82.8	33	58.9
The ability to continue developing professionally.	12	44.4	5	17.2	17	30.4
Addressing challenges/problems as they arise in daily operations.	10	37.0	5	17.2	15	26.8
More understanding of the human resource field (e.g., training, recognising staff's strengths).	10	37.0	1	3.4	11	19.6
Bolstering leadership skills (e.g., managing and supporting staff).	9	33.3	2	6.9	11	19.6
Displaying operational skills (e.g., a more dynamic workflow, a more well-rounded expertise).	8	29.6	3	10.3	11	19.6
Fostering a spirit of teamwork learning (e.g., caring for fellow employees, mutual sharing, mutual learning).	7	25.9	3	10.3	10	17.9
Stronger customer orientation (e.g., effective communication, engaging with guests).	5	18.5	4	13.8	9	16.1
Gaining more IT-related skills.	5	18.5	2	6.9	7	12.5
Demonstrating business administration-related skills (e.g., asset management, financial management).	4	14.8	3	10.3	7	12.5
Learning foreign languages for my work.	3	11.1	3	10.3	6	10.7

* Percentages were rounded off as appropriate.

Fig. 2. How current knowledge equips older hospitality employees.

Further reinforcing QCA, Gioia (2021) explains that research findings should "make sense to the informants as knowledgeable actors… also should be adequate at the level of theoretical insight" (p. 23). To address this expectation, research must convey first-order terms, where the focus is on the informants (informant-centred) and second-order themes, which relate to a theory-centred (Gioia, 2021) or a researcher-centred focus (Gioia et al., 2013). Upon achieving a widespread set of first and second-order terms and themes, respectively, aggregate dimensions are developed (Gioia et al., 2013). Overall, the data structure guides the understanding of the relationships between first-order terms, second-order themes, and aggregate dimensions (Gioia, 2021). The development of these three key elements is followed by the development of a model depicting their dynamic relationships and how they "describe or explain the phenomenon of interest and one that makes clear all relevant data-to-theory connections" (Gioia et al., 2013, p. 22). Figs. 1–3 illustrate the data structure method, while Fig. 4 presents the resulting model.

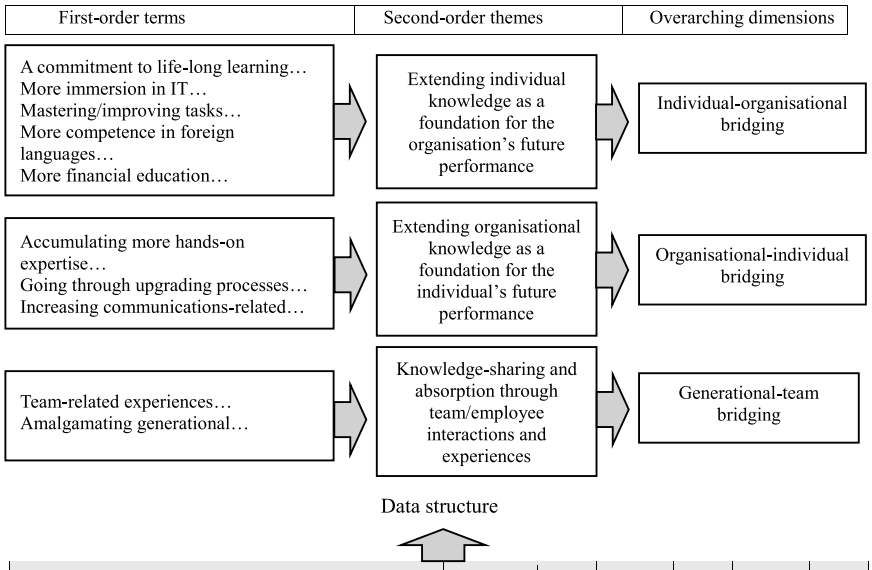
Trustworthiness is the degree to which a study's results authentically reflect the lived or personal experiences of the phenomenon being examined (Curtin and Fossey, 2007). Guba's (1981) seminal research delineated the following criteria to address trustworthiness issues in qualitative research:

Credibility, which relates to whether the research findings are congruent with reality is contingent upon individual judgements (Stahl and King, 2020). Triangulation in different forms can promote credibility, including methodological, data, and investigator triangulation; these were applied in the present research.

Dependability: The notion that repeating a study using the same methods, participants and in a similar context would yield comparable findings (Shenton, 2004). To promote dependability, Shenton (2004) recommends, for instance, a thorough description of the research design and its implementation; this aspect was presented in this section.

Confirmability is akin to a researcher's concern with objectivity, whereby the informant's ideas and experiences, not the researcher's preferences, should be reflected in the findings (Shenton, 2004). Among other ways to promote confirmability, Shenton (2004) once again emphasises the importance of triangulation.

Transferability: Stahl and King (2020) contend that this proposition is problematic given that qualitative inquiry's purpose does not include aims for replicability. Because transferability is not to be "apportioned



Future knowledge includes:	Owner/ manager (n=27)	%*	Staff (n=29)	%*	Total (n=56)	%*
Accumulating more hands-on expertise over the years (e.g., becoming a generalist).	19	70.4	19	65.5	38	67.9
Going through upgrading processes (diligence-related, team management, task delegation) to be more adaptable.	19	70.4	12	41.4	31	55.4
A commitment to lifelong learning (e.g., attitudinal and mindset-related).	19	70.4	10	34.5	29	51.8
More immersion in information technology (IT).	13	48.1	10	34.5	23	41.1
Team-related experiences (e.g., organising/working in teams to brainstorm and share data/information).	9	33.3	3	10.3	12	21.4
Mastering/improving tasks that help me/the firm gain professional recognition.	9	33.3	2	6.9	11	19.6
Increasing communications-related skills (e.g., communicating with customers).	4	14.8	2	6.9	6	10.7
Amalgamating generational wisdom (e.g., own expertise and learning from younger generations).	4	14.8	0	0.0	4	7.1
More competence in foreign languages.	1	3.7	2	6.9	3	5.4
More financial education (e.g., to improve tasks and performance).	2	7.4	0	0.0	2	3.6

* Percentages were rounded off as appropriate.

Fig. 3. What future knowledge will equip older hospitality workers.

by the researcher… [it] must be imputed by those who wish to compare the research with their personal contexts" (Stahl and King, 2020, p. 27). Thus this research's transferability potential is limited.

3.4. Demographic data

Older workers shared similar characteristics regarding their roles and age groups (Table 1). However, differences were noticed in other aspects, including a gender imbalance, their estimated remaining years working in the hospitality industry, and their city of residence (Hanoi). In addition, a clear predominance of highly experienced individuals (6–10 years versus 11 years and above) was noted. This finding demonstrates that the study not only gathered data from individuals who matched the 'older employee' category in terms of age but also regarding their time or work experience in years. Regarding their weekly and daily workload, at the time of the study, more than two-thirds of participants worked at least five days per week, and almost 70 per cent worked at least eight hours daily. The largest participant cohorts were involved in management and housekeeping. In the next section, selected participants' comments will be abbreviated as P1M (participant 1, managerial role), P1NM (participant 1, non-managerial role), etc.

4. Results

4.1. The relevance of previous knowledge

The analysis of this first area (Q1) reveals the importance of knowledge in boosting older employees' performance in the hospitality business, for instance, through the more optimal performance of firm-related tasks and monitoring operational aspects more effectively (Fig. 1). P6NM (Housekeeping assistant), for instance, recognised:

> Accumulating experience and keen observation have allowed me to tailor solutions to specific problems and individuals… My advantage lies in having pursued various courses in business administration, allowing me to effectively apply these skills to my work…

Secondly, previous knowledge was relevant internally, in sharing knowledge, conducting activities to disseminate and improve work-related knowledge and improving one's interpersonal skills to function more effectively within teams. Regarding this finding, Mota Veiga et al. (2023) stress the significance of 'knowledge spillovers', characterised by

Table 1
Demographic information of the participants.

Role	n = 56	%*
Managerial	27	51.8
Non-managerial (staff)	29	48.2
Age	**n = 56**	**%***
50–55	28	50.0
56–65**	28	50.0
Gender	**n = 56**	**%***
Female	39	69.6
Male	17	30.4
Years of experience in the hospitality industry	**n = 56**	**%***
6–10	3	5.4
11 and above	53	94.6
Working location	**n = 56**	**%***
Hanoi	46	82.1
Other cities/provinces	10	17.9
Weekly workload	**n = 56**	**%***
Less than 5 days	17	30.4
5 days	16	28.6
More than 5 days	23	41.0
Daily workload	**n = 56**	**%***
Less than an 8-hour shift	17	30.4
An 8-hour shift	17	30.4
More than an 8-hour shift	22	39.3
Estimated years to continue to work in the industry	**n = 56**	**%***
5 or less	23	41.1
6 or more	33	58.9
Work areas/departments	**n = 56**	**%***
Management	22	39.3
Housekeeping	10	17.9
Kitchen help	6	10.7
Public areas (e.g., gardening, lobby)	6	10.7
Restaurant	4	7.1
Security	3	5.4
Laundry services	3	5.4
Other (chef, engineer/maintenance)	2	3.6

** 16 participants in this group were over 60 years old.
* Some percentages were rounded off.

knowledge spreading across individuals, their firm, the local space and the organisational fabric. P2M (Hotel chief engineer) shared the impacts of benefitting from earlier acquired knowledge and being a recipient of a 'paying it forward' notion among the firm's employees:

> The knowledge that I previously acquired by being sent to international training and accumulated while working with different generations of hotel managers has helped me professionally… I spread it [the knowledge] among my employees to build a strong team… Every month, I have skill-sharing sessions for our hotel staff…

Thirdly, previous knowledge boosted the older worker's confidence, resilience and motivational levels, and fourthly, it facilitated the hotel-guest understanding where knowledge was a catalyst for conveying messages that can reassure guests. P28M (Hotel general manager), for instance, shared: *"Previous knowledge has enabled me to understand the psychology of customers and employees, thereby helping me handle each case. It has also helped in operational aspects and ways to increase revenue…"* Understanding customers could be reciprocated by customers' knowledge sharing (Guan et al., 2018), thus benefiting the hospitality firm in direct feedback or recommendations. Further reflecting on knowledge-based experiences, P11M (Restaurant department head) shared the learning journey prior to making a start in the hospitality industry:

> The first skill that comes to mind is IT skills. When I transitioned from working at a Chinese restaurant to a warehouse keeper, where I gained exposure to computer usage. Consequently, when I was promoted to a supervisor position and tasked with generating computerised reports, I was already familiar with the process.

This last comment, again, underlines the importance of employee-customer interaction, which can be the source of innovative ideas, with the employee being instrumental in taking these to a higher level, that is, turning them into innovations (Nieves et al., 2014) where both customers and the firm benefit. Whereas the study considered both managers and non-managers, representatives of the first group had built their current role from subordinate/entry-level roles. As shown (Fig. 1),

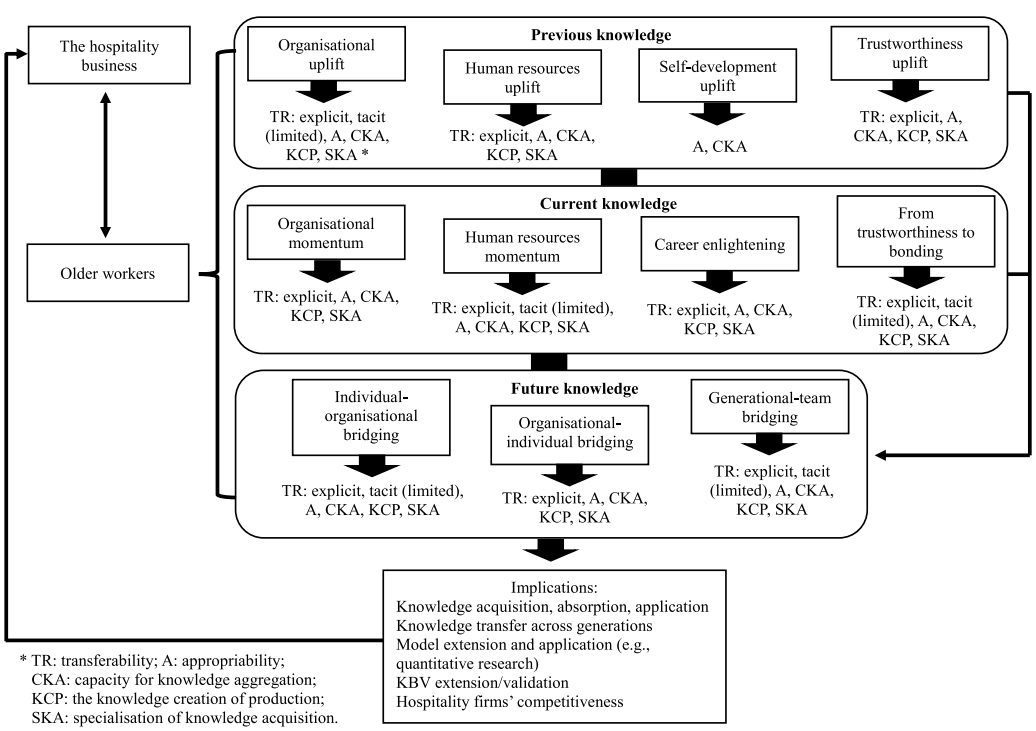


Fig. 4. Older hospitality workers' previous, current and future knowledge and the KBV. Sources include Grant (1996); Grant and Phene (2022); Schoenherr (2022); Schlegel and Kraus (2023).

their current job position was a determinant factor concerning their observations on knowledge and knowledge management. For instance, managers were clearly more assertive regarding eight of the 10 themes, some of which suggested leadership, decision-making, or supervision.

4.2. The relevance of current knowledge

The magnitude of current knowledge (Q2) was mainly perceived in terms of a progression from earlier experiences through which knowledge was acquired and fortified with implications for the organisation and the individual older employee (Fig. 2). This finding was particularly demonstrated by observations regarding the role that older employees played in strengthening their performance in regular tasks, emerging situations where swift problem-solving knowledge and skills were required, as well as an overall competency in operational matters. For instance, working in the hotel's laundry services, the following observations underline the progression from basic tasks to becoming more knowledgeable over the years and capitalising on current knowledge (P30NM, Laundry department attendant): *"To excel [in this job] one must possess excellent skills in identifying and categorising stains and mastering the methods of dealing with these… mishandling them can result in costly damage to the hotel's equipment."* Current knowledge was further demonstrated by older employees' ability to react and solve problems as they occurred; among other comments, P14M (Head of security) posited:

> Within my security department, I must handle situations that arise at work. Applying the hotel's standard operating procedures (SOPs) is one way, and the rest will come from the experiences I have accumulated over a long working process… not every situation will be available in the SOPs. In addition, computer skills and foreign language skills are a must.

The human resources domain is an additional area where current knowledge permeates firm-older employees or those holding managerial positions and their subordinates. In referring to the need to observe and understand the firm's employees, P1NM (Cost control assistant manager) posited: *"Each individual has a unique approach… recognising employees' strengths facilitates arranging and assigning work in the most suitable manner."* This observation accentuates the relevance of supervisory styles in encouraging employees' learning orientation (Shamim et al., 2017). Unsurprisingly, information technology (IT) and the ability to further professional development were perceived as instrumental forms of current knowledge with potential consequences for future performance and effects on the hospitality industry; as P5M (Hotel general manager) noted:

> The hotel management system being used is connected to a third party. When there is a system crash, I have to specify whether I can handle it myself or I have to report it to [company name's headquarters]. The support office in Paris is in a different time zone, so sometimes we cannot contact them, and I cannot support our staff to solve the problem… I have to learn more to be able to support my employees.

Current knowledge was also associated with the enhancement of relationships with customers; in this context, communication and engagement were perceived to be influenced by a stronger mastery of foreign languages. Differences between the managerial and non-managerial cohorts were also quite apparent (Fig. 2). Knowledge was much more prevalent among non-managerial staff in completing regular firm-related tasks, while both groups perceived the need to learn foreign languages almost equally. However, eight other areas aligned more strongly with managers' involvement and routines.

4.3. Future knowledge requirements

Three main themes emerged regarding how future knowledge could help older employees continue their hospitality careers (Q3, Fig. 3). First, there was a clear intention and eagerness to prolong the journey of knowledge acquisition and application. As P3NM (Assistant front office manager) posited, self-development through a commitment to life-long learning, proficiency in completing tasks, and improving foreign language or financial knowledge were key components of future learning processes: *"Apart from learning how to use computer software [and] work apps on the phone to keep up with business requirements… You also have to regularly update your professional knowledge and foreign languages."*

While challenges along the way were identified, older workers still positively reflected on their journey and the benefits to be accrued from future learning (P1NM, Cost control assistant manager): "*At an older age… the learning speed might be slower compared to younger individuals. However, it is essential to keep up with technological advancements because they have become integral to most aspects of work."* Despite perceptions of being less able to adapt to technological developments, as well as being less productive or competent compared to their younger hospitality peers (Cheung and Woo, 2021), in this study, older workers valued the importance of further knowledge acquisition.

Second, older workers' perceptions of future knowledge at an individual level spilled over into the organisation. For instance, accumulating practical knowledge, experiencing upgrading processes, or applying knowledge to communicating with customers can elevate individual knowledge and positively affect the hospitality organisation. P7NM (Executive assistant manager) noted: *"We must stay abreast of industry developments and avoid falling behind. Additionally, customer needs are ever-changing; they never wait for us to catch up or change; rather, we must adjust to suit their evolving expectations."* This comment is partly aligned with contemporary research (Shamim et al., 2017) ascertaining customers' increasing expectations and the need for hotels to convert employees' knowledge into the firm's intellectual assets, thereby maintaining its standards.

Third, perceived future knowledge was also embodied through the enhancement of internal work processes, in particular, sharing and absorbing with and from other workers. Partly associated with recent research (Willems and Poon, 2024), another important aspect is the willingness and readiness of older workers to amalgamate knowledge between themselves and their younger peers or subordinates. Additionally, the role played by the younger worker generations was viewed positively, particularly due to their up-to-date knowledge, including knowledge of trends, ideas or some technologies (P5M Hotel general manager):

> I acknowledge youngsters' creativity, intelligence, and abundance of innovative ideas… This does not diminish the value of experience; instead, when experience is complemented by youths' insights, the resulting synergy leads to optimal outcomes… Youngsters also want to be acknowledged, and they like being asked for their opinions and expressing themselves.

As many youngsters might replace the 'old hospitality guard' (Goh and Lee, 2018), they too might benefit from older workers' wisdom and expertise. Therefore, improving the work structure of hospitality firms, including through generational blending (Chi et al., 2013), could help facilitate the employee succession process. Fig. 3 illustrates differences between those in managerial and non-managerial roles. As with Figs. 1–2, the first group was predominant in most responses; a plausible reason for this outcome is their leadership role that demands deeper levels of knowledge acquisition, absorption and application. However, a similar percentage of both groups' participants indicated the desire to accumulate future knowledge through hands-on experience.

5. Discussion

The present study contributes to advancing a relevant yet under-researched line of inquiry. Nevertheless, the study's main motivation was not merely to fill the existing research vacuum on the experiences of older hospitality workers (e.g., Madera et al., 2023), particularly in

regard to knowledge-based domains. Instead, the study's scope includes broadening the discourse related to how knowledge and knowledge management permeate the professional journeys of older workers, thereby developing practitioner and conceptual understanding. More importantly, the study makes two fundamental conceptual contributions. First, it developed a theoretical framework based on data structure and qualitative content analysis, enhancing the rigour of qualitative inquiry (e.g., Gioia, 2021; Gioia et al., 2013). The revealed dimensions provide a solid foundation for conceptually reflecting upon, deepening understanding and assessing different stages of knowledge (past, present and future) from the perspective of older hospitality workers. Consequently, important implications emerge for their organisations and for managing their knowledge pool. Second, the study evaluated the usefulness of the KBV's characteristics of knowledge as presented by Grant (1996). This evaluation added to the depth of the research and helped ascertain numerous areas where a) the characteristics' usefulness was established and b) several shortcomings in both the dimensions and the characteristics' scope were identified.

More specifically, investigating how previous knowledge helped equip older workers' professional careers (Q1) resulted in the emergence of four dimensions based on the crafting of terms and themes. The organisational uplift dimension can be used as a marker to understand how older employees' previous knowledge has various direct impacts on the hospitality organisation's performance, including through task completion and problem-solving.

The human resource uplift dimension denotes the value of previous knowledge in enriching the firm's human resource domain, where accumulated knowledge, expertise, and skills can be critical in older workers' professional development. One illustration is by sharing knowledge with potential spillovers positively affecting fellow workers or the hospitality firm (Mota Veiga et al., 2023) or by building one's leadership skills within the organisation. Associated with these skills, the self-development uplift dimension illuminates the relevance of previous knowledge in shaping the older worker's human and professional mindset. Here, the accumulated knowledge acts as a cushion, supporting and strengthening the employee's confidence, resilience, and motivational levels. This dimension also explains the transformation of explicit into tacit knowledge as workers' knowledge progressively becomes personal and subjective, also requiring simultaneous processing (Nonaka et al., 2000; Schoenherr, 2022).

Lastly, the trustworthiness uplift dimension stands for the operationalisation of previous knowledge as a mechanism helping reinforce older employee-customer trust, peace of mind and confidence in the transactions with the hospitality business. This dimension, therefore, has links to the management of knowledge flows, where the organisation can apply particular knowledge that bolsters innovation activities (Mota Veiga et al., 2023), in this case, by acquiring ideas through interactions with customers.

The above four dimensions provide a critical first step, a strong foundation and a transition connecting previous and current knowledge (Q2). Indeed, current knowledge can also be explained by four dimensions. The first, organisational momentum, underscores the fortifying impact of current knowledge on the organisation's performance, thus suggesting the links between previous and current knowledge. At the current stage, participants are more seasoned and informed workers who can reinforce and apply knowledge to address everyday situations and predicaments, supporting task completion or improving operational skills. Similarly, the human resource momentum dimension explains the reinforcing effect of current knowledge on other staff members and displaying leadership skills.

The career-enlightening dimension illuminates the juxtaposition between knowledge acquisition and motivational factors, where older workers perceive current knowledge as a career-enriching tool. Partly related to this finding, a study focusing on senior hospitality employees (Ann and Blum, 2020) found that work and recognition were powerful job satisfaction predictors. Finally, the 'from trustworthiness to bonding' dimension sheds light on the transitional period between building relationships with customers (Fig. 1). This finding underlines a deepening of those initial bonds through interaction and mutual trust, potentially creating benefits throughout patronage for the organisation, more personalised or improved service for customers, and further recognition and enhanced knowledge for older workers.

The study also contributes to elucidating significant aspects of future knowledge among older hospitality workers, as outlined in three dimensions (Q3). The individual-organisational bridging dimension enhances the understanding of the role and impact of the individual older worker on the organisation. The multiple forms of knowledge improvements (Fig. 3) underscore benefits that can be accrued by older employees' involvement in knowledge-based practices. Understanding future knowledge's effects through the organisational-individual bridging dimension is also useful as it suggests the impacts that organisational-related knowledge can have at an individual level, where the applied knowledge also enriches the individual. While seemingly peripheral based on participants' observations, the generational-team bridging dimension facilitates the understanding of the vital need for hospitality organisations to foster stronger bonds between the older and newer worker generations; this aspect is suggested in the academic literature (e.g., Lee and Kim, 2017). The implications stemming from this and other crafted dimensions will be discussed next.

5.1. Theoretical implications

Emanating from the above discussion, the study's analysis also underlines various theoretical implications. First, the 11 revealed dimensions provide a set of notions that can facilitate present and future understanding of how older workers, through acquired knowledge at different points in time, can be impactful towards their organisation, peers, subordinates, and themselves, in extending their expertise. Second, and similarly, the crafted framework (Fig. 4) provides a conceptual map that can illuminate knowledge and knowledge management from various perspectives, including those of practitioners, academics and governments.

As the results suggest, older workers' previous knowledge can be vital in shaping current and future performance, both at an organisational and individual level. In seeking to understand old workers' potential contribution, researchers could consider the four emerging dimensions as a template to develop a questionnaire tool to study this domain more broadly from a quantitative perspective. The strong connections between previous and current knowledge or the three dimensions associated with future knowledge also offer opportunities for researchers in various ways. For instance, the dimensions have implications for the potential identification of additional dimensions that help explain this progression, leading to organisational and individual outcomes.

Similarly, there are opportunities for researchers to delve deeper into the non-managerial realm to ascertain first-order terms and second-order themes that could further illuminate the impacts of knowledge at various points in older employees' careers. Moreover, there are implications from considering the different dimensions, particularly current and future knowledge to also understand knowledge's impact on younger hospitality worker generations. This line of research could be useful in drawing comparisons with older employees' experiential journeys and, by extension, enriching theoretical knowledge related to both groups.

Third, the amalgamation between the dimensions and the framework provides strong evidence of the insightfulness of considering, reflecting on and embracing the KBV's tenets to provide a deeper understanding of older workers' knowledge acquisition, synthesising, and application. For instance, whereas tacit knowledge was partly associated with five dimensions (Fig. 4), explicit knowledge became apparent in 10 dimensions. Furthermore, this finding highlights their value as robust conceptual alternatives to understand older hospitality employees' past,

present, and future knowledge, with implications for organisational knowledge management. A similar outcome was also noticed when relationships were evaluated between these and the five characteristics of the KBV (Grant, 1996; Grant and Phene, 2022; Schoenherr, 2022; Schlegel and Kraus, 2023). These relationships are based on first-order codes (Figs. 1–3), which expand or overlap at least over one other characteristic of knowledge. For instance, despite the structured nature of RQ1-RQ3 in the literature review, the semi-structured open-ended interviews provided a broad range of comments that helped craft the organisational uplift dimension (Fig. 1).

As illustrated, this dimension is grounded on performing professional tasks more optimally, monitoring operations more effectively or being more successful at solving work-related problems. The richness of these illustrations of previous knowledge underscores relationships with knowledge appropriability, capacity for knowledge aggregation, the knowledge requirements of production and specialisation in knowledge acquisition. Similar arguments are made for the majority of the other dimensions, thereby ascertaining the appropriateness of the KBV as a conceptual lens to illuminate the context of the present research (RQ4).

Despite these demonstrations of alignment and mutual reinforcement, and as previously suggested, several shortcomings must be acknowledged. First, only two associations emerged between the self-development uplift dimension and the characteristics of knowledge, namely, appropriability and the capacity for knowledge aggregation (Fig. 4). Second, a lack of connection between the self-development uplift dimension and tacit or explicit knowledge is also apparent. At the same time, however, these modest alignments do not diminish the usefulness of this dimension in helping understand aspects that can strengthen older workers' cognitive and psychological aptitudes and mindset, with implications for their adaptiveness to hospitality environments.

Third, only five dimensions presented some level of connection to tacit knowledge, while the other 10 revealed stronger connections to explicit knowledge. This apparent shortcoming is partly due to the nature of the research, which focused on individual experiences rather than groups or entire organisations. Moreover, while tacit knowledge among the participants was confirmed, such knowledge is present in all three stages of knowledge, particularly in current and perceived future knowledge. Thus, there is value in interpreting these results when assessing the usefulness of Fig. 4 in future research, a) by considering only the developed dimensions (Figs. 1–3) or b) amalgamating these with the tenets of the KBV (Fig. 4).

5.2. Practical implications

Various practical implications are recognised. One among others identified in this research relates to the generational-team bridging dimension (Fig. 3). By studying both individuals who have achieved managerial roles and those who remained in non-managerial positions, differences in perceptions and actions towards knowledge acquisition and application can have beneficial impacts. Indeed, focusing on the generational-team dimension could be helpful in guiding future generations of hospitality leaders, as well as enhancing the understanding of the knowledge journey of those who have remained in non-managerial roles. Furthermore, managers' stellar progress and ascent to their current roles could serve as a motivational boost to other workers, particularly younger generations, in exchanging and absorbing knowledge from seasoned individuals. Thus, older employees, both in managerial or non-managerial roles, could make key contributions to inspire other individuals within the firm to adapt and guide their career in the hospitality industry, potentially leading to filling some of its perennial gaps and helping address the high turnover rates (Frye et al., 2020).

To maximise their impact on this area, as well as on the organisation (organisational uplift/momentum dimensions, Figs. 1–2), older workers need to continue updating and furthering their professional development. Thus, equally important is the self-development uplift (Fig. 1), where earlier work experiences help build a career's foundation. One of the indirect consequences is the provision of more responsible and personalised services, enhancing customers' trust (trustworthiness uplift dimension). With the advent of generations of older workers remaining active in the future (Croes et al., 2024; Kooij et al., 2020), there are implications for organisations that align with recommended older employee retention strategies (Ravichandran et al., 2015) or mentorship initiatives (Lee and Kim, 2017).

Similarly, there are implications for guidance and leadership within hospitality operations' human resource area. This implication is depicted by the human resource uplift/momentum dimensions, which underscore the accumulated previous and current knowledge to play pivotal roles. These roles also denote an evolving process, where, as illustrated by some comments, over time employees take up greater responsibilities and undergo phases and an evolutionary path towards higher positions, eventually leading the organisation. The long process should also involve the organisation beyond supporting, motivating and rewarding the employee to create a culture where the older and younger employees can interact and exchange knowledge. Once again, the generational-team bridging dimension affords an insightful conceptual notion facilitating the understanding of this implication.

Implications also arise for policymakers, community leaders, and local councils in developing initiatives to recruit and develop talent among older employees. These initiatives could partly address increasing labour needs and demands (e.g., Peng and Chan, 2019) while helping transmit knowledge, skills and a professional mindset, together with 'paying it forward' attitudinal attributes.

5.3. Limitations and future research

The study presents several limitations that can also motivate future research endeavours. First, while the study's selected qualitative research provides numerous valuable benefits, the number of participants, together with the representation of different hotel departments, is limited. An opportunity, therefore, arises for future investigations to adopt a more systematic approach, where the selection of two or more predominant groups can complement the present study's findings. Furthermore, future research could enhance this study's findings by eliciting data from larger numbers of individuals working in a variety of positions. Doing so would not only acknowledge the voice of a diverse cohort of participants but also potentially identify similarities and differences in perceptions of knowledge-based approaches.

Second, the study only focuses on older employees operating in Vietnam's hospitality industry. Although selecting this nation provides invaluable insights into knowledge's impact among older employees, the study's geographic scope is limited. Future research could consider examining the views of older workers in other nations, including in different continents and socioeconomic contexts. This line of inquiry could yield useful comparative analysis that would extend the present research's findings and analysis, for instance, helping deepen practitioner and conceptual understanding. Along these lines, while the developed conceptual framework (Fig. 4) has merit in gaining awareness and in reflecting upon the impact of knowledge across different times, it lacks validation from subsequent studies. Hence, an additional opportunity emerges for future research to assess its usefulness.

6. Conclusion

This study accomplished several objectives. First, it examined how older hospitality employees' careers are shaped by previous, current and future knowledge. Incorporating the KBV underpinnings and conducting semi-structured open-ended interviews with older workers in managerial and non-managerial roles, the study illuminated an under-researched yet critical area and contributed to the limited research on older hospitality and tourism workers (Madera et al., 2023). With much of the world's working environments continuing to experience the aging

population phenomenon and with the need for older workers to remain active, the present research provides a timely empirical and conceptual understanding. Second, partly in line with Cheung and Woo's (2021) research, this study contributes to the limited body of research focusing on older workers' self-perceptions in relation to their profession using a qualitative approach. Third, the data analysis revealed 11 conceptual dimensions. These dimensions were further strengthened by crafting a framework (Fig. 4), which extends beyond the study's analysis to also identify relationships with the characteristics of the KBV. At the same time, various shortcomings regarding the scope of some of the emerging dimensions vis-à-vis the KBV's characteristics were revealed. Despite the acknowledged shortcomings, the dimensions, together with the assessments of the KBV characteristics, not only complement the findings but also ascertain the value of the KBV in understanding previous, current and future knowledge among older employees.

CRediT authorship contribution statement

Oanh Thi Kim Vu: Writing – review & editing, Supervision, Investigation, Conceptualization. **Luong Ngoc Tran:** Writing – review & editing, Validation, Investigation. **Giang Huong Vu:** Writing – review & editing, Formal analysis. **Abel Duarte Alonso:** Writing – original draft, Visualization, Validation, Methodology, Investigation, Formal analysis, Data curation, Conceptualization. **Trung Thanh Nguyen:** Visualization, Investigation, Data curation, Conceptualization.

Declaration

This study received no funding; no conflict of interest was uncovered.

Declaration of Competing Interest

The authors declare that no conflict of interest is/was identified in this research.

Data availability

Data will be made available on request.

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